One has to feel some sympathy for Chelmsford. For it is undoubted that he faced one of the most difficult periods of British rule in India, caught as he was between the Conservatives in London, who opposed too many concessions to the Indian people, and those Liberals and Indian agitators who pushed for greater reform to the rule of the Raj. This is not to mention his having to continually battle with the Home government over Britain's Asian policy at large, while also desperately keeping a lid on Muslim and nationalist agitation and Bolshevik sedition. The post-war period was a time of high tension between those on the different ends of the political spectrum and if Chelmsford was inclined towards caution in his work, perhaps that was the necessary strategy, given his need to placate so many disparate groups. Chelmsford himself was aware of the accusation of weakness that were being made against him:

I am told that people say that my Council run me. I am indifferent to that accusation...I think you will own that I had only to lift my little finger and I could have obtained dissent from the majority of the proposals to which you and I with certainly the bulk of my colleagues have given agreement.[102]

Some have tended to be more positive towards the viceroy than others, believing that Chelmsford governed astutely by looking for consensus among his colleagues.[103] Some contemporaries were also generous about the viceroy. One report written in 1921, for example, summed up his tenure thus: 'To few Governor-Generals has it been given to accomplish so much towards the enduring welfare of their great charge; to fewer yet has the meed of praise and appreciation been so scantily rendered.'[104]

Nevertheless, whether it was justified or not, Montagu certainly appeared happier to have Reading as his viceroy, always referring to him by his first name, Rufus, in their correspondence (which he had not done with Chelmsford) and continually praising his work in India.[105] For his part, while he may have been more adept at coping with Montagu's particular personality, Reading did not actually differ greatly in his policies from that which had been followed by Chelmsford.[106] Hence, the Afghan